Meanwhile, in MP, former Congress CM Kamal Nath added more fuel to the fire with his breezy comment on Akhilesh's demand for seats. "*Arre bhai, chhodo Akhilesh-vakhilesh ko*, we are winning the polls," which again roused the SP chief into nasty rejoinders.

Sensing things were getting out of hand, the Congress top brass intervened. Party sources say organisation secretary K.C. Venugopal was deputed to talk to Akhilesh. Later, the SP chief said he had got a call from the Congress's "tallest leader" and the matter had been resolved. "*Agar woh kuchh kah rahe hain, toh unki baat maanni padegi* (If a leader of such stature is saying something, I will have to acknowledge it)," Akhilesh said. But he added for good measure: "After MP, I understand the INDIA alliance is only for the 'Bharat' elections. When that comes up, we too will think over it [seat allotment]..... Ultimately, the issue is credibility. If the Congress continues with this kind of behaviour, who will stand with it?"

The 28-party INDIA formation had framed the 2024 electoral contest as a united fight against the BJP, but that centripetal pull seems to have dissipated within months. The Congress decision to go solo in MP was just the culmination of tensions that had been brewing between the party's state unit and the SP for a while. Back in August, then Congress state chief Brijlal Khabri had given an interview where he said the party cadre wanted to sever all ties with the SP. Akhilesh now says the SP will contest seven seats in MP. In 2018, the party had won one seat (Nithwara) and come second in another five, with 1.3 per cent of the total vote). With one eye on the caste census fallout, the SP chief has also been putting out cryptic tweets on how the party's focus will be on the PDA (Pichada, Dalit and Alpsankhyak) communities, an acronym he coined recently.

The BJP is naturally overjoyed at the events. UP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi was heard gloating: "They are wrestling among themselves in the states. This is the true face of Opposition unity. It is completely hollow. Now they will destroy each other." ■



PUNJAB

EMBARRASSING EXODUS FOR BJP

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

In the first week of October, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's images from the Golden Temple in Amritsar—head covered in blue scarf, hearing Gurbani *kirtan* and performing *sewa* (community service)—flashed across media. Though, on Rahul's request, the Punjab Congress unit termed the two-day visit a personal one, the local party unit arranged a meeting between three-time MLA Raj Kumar Verka—a long-time Congressman who had joined the BJP in June 2022—and Rahul. Two weeks later, on October 14, Verka led one of the biggest exoduses from the BJP, back into the Congress. The posse included, other than Verka, Balbir Sidhu, Gurpreet Kangar (both vice-presidents of the Punjab BJP) and Sunder Shyam Arora—all four were ministers in the Amarinder Singh/Charanjit Singh Channi Congress regime who had joined the BJP a year back—as well as former MLA Amrik Dhillon and former Mohali mayor Amarjit Sidhu.

The desertion of leaders deals the BJP a blow not only in Punjab, but also subverts their countrywide practice of enticing leaders from other parties, enabling them to have a footprint in new areas. The assimilation of such turncoats into the BJP has, however, remained a challenge in West Bengal, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Telangana.